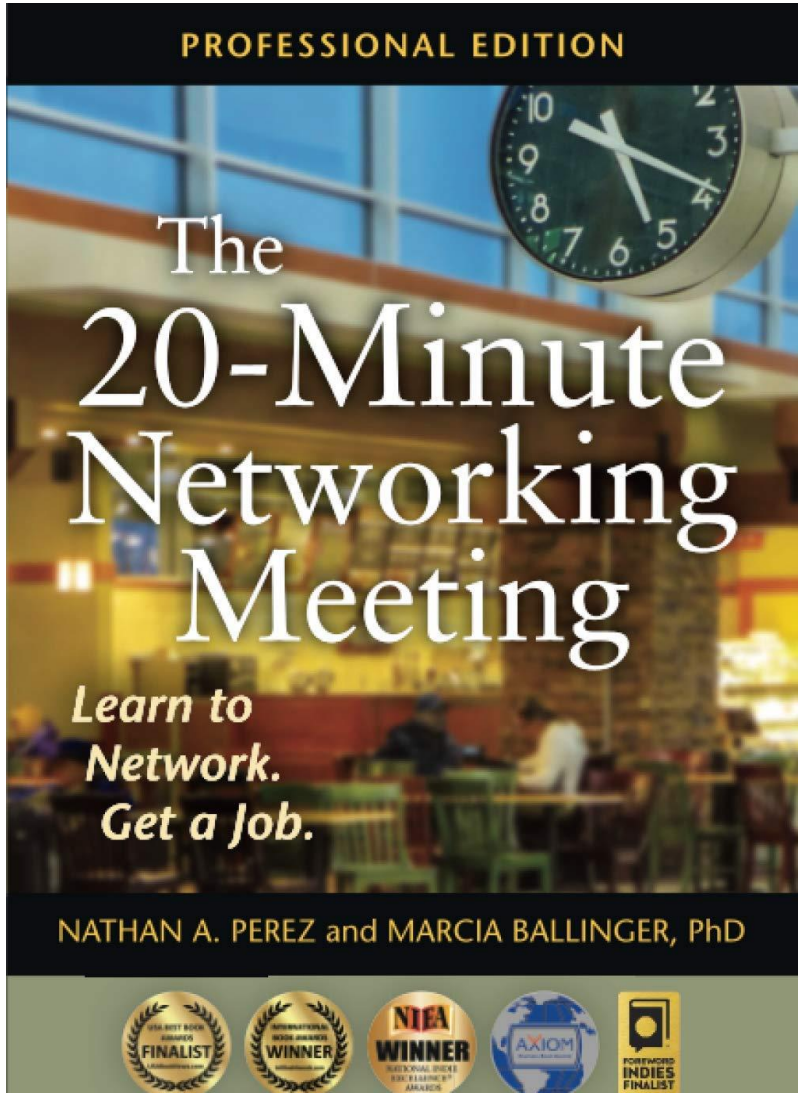
USC Marshall
School of Business
Graduate Career Services

Elevate Your Networking Strategy: Proven Strategies for Career Success

Informational Interviews

- Read the book
  – prepare for the meeting

- This seminar
  – the before and after



Networking is . . .

building and maintaining

courteous,

positive,

mutually beneficial,

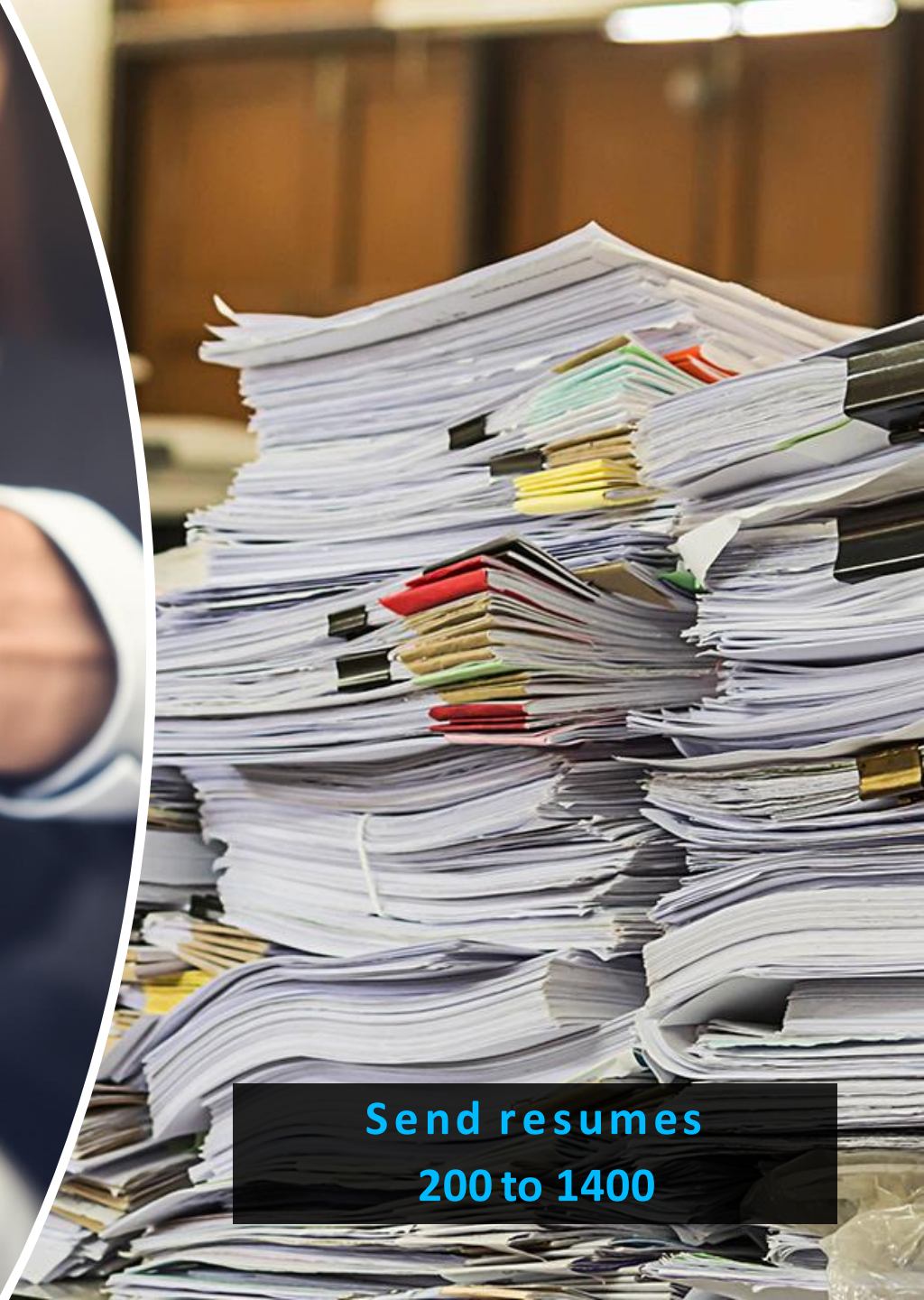
professional relationships

Relationships *matter*

Success often depends on engaging in relationships with others

How you engage will impact your success!

Network
12 informational interviews



Send resumes
200 to 1400

NETWORKING MATTERS

Visible vs. invisible job market

Job Ads

Recruiters & Hiring Agencies

Professional Associations

Connections to Hiring Manager's team

Hiring Manager's connections

Internal candidates/Lateral hires

"I want to help! Be open about what you hope to get out of the conversation."

- Class of 2021 MBA Alumnus

Alumni LinkedIn Poll: *When an MBA student contacts you for networking, and* ***their goal is an internal referral****, how many chats do you want before you refer them?*

At least 2-3+ chats	**49%**
At least 1 chat	**41%**
Just ask	**<10%**

Networking happens *everywhere*
company events
career fair
conferences
roundtables
mixers/socials
alumni events

How comfortable are you with Networking?

#1 – I love it! Where are my business cards?

#2 – I get it, I'm ok doing it

#3 – Not comfortable, I don't really enjoy it

#4 – It's schmoozy, it's phony, I hate it!

What are your questions about Networking?

What do you want to know?

What are the do's and don'ts of networking?

What is the appropriate way to approach a professional to ask for a coffee chat?

Which functions/industries/companies really use networking for recruiting? Are there industry-specific tips for networking?

What are the strategies to follow up and maintain a connection with someone?

How do you assess the success of networking efforts?

Networking preparation

- **identify** “customer” needs
- develop your **brand** and message
- **communicate** your brand
- create **alignment** to your value

Dissect the Ad | Resume | Self-intro practice

Company & Contact Research | Meeting Agenda

Get organized

Create and maintain a company list

- “Company Target List” in 12Twenty Library
- Adapt or create a spreadsheet tracker
- 20 to 30 companies to start

Add contact names and manage data

- Identify 2 to 3 alumni or connections per company
- Name, title, email, LinkedIn, meeting dates, notes, etc.

Calendar

- Add scheduled chats (notes, questions list, LI link)
- Add follow up reminders to re-connect with the contact

Chats with Class of 2024

- Schedule now! 5-10 each week, 15-20 minutes

Strategize and prioritize

Company, Industry, Function

- Recruiting timelines by function and/or industry
- Current openings, rolling applications, or hard deadlines?
- Your interest level, popularity, competition

Contacts/Connections

- What is their role or title?
- Team member? Hiring manager? Executive?
- Can they get you a closer connection?

You!

- Current comfort level
- Networking experience
- Bottom-up vs. top-down networking

Use insights from SY students
Prioritize companies of strongest functional interest

Bottom-up Networking

Wisdom

vision, strategy, organizational alignment, industry, long-term corporate planning, internal relationships

Knowledge

company, market, competitors, department or division, cross-team collaboration, mid-career facts

Information & Data

function, company info, company culture, recruiting info, day-on-the-job, early career facts

Begin at Marshall

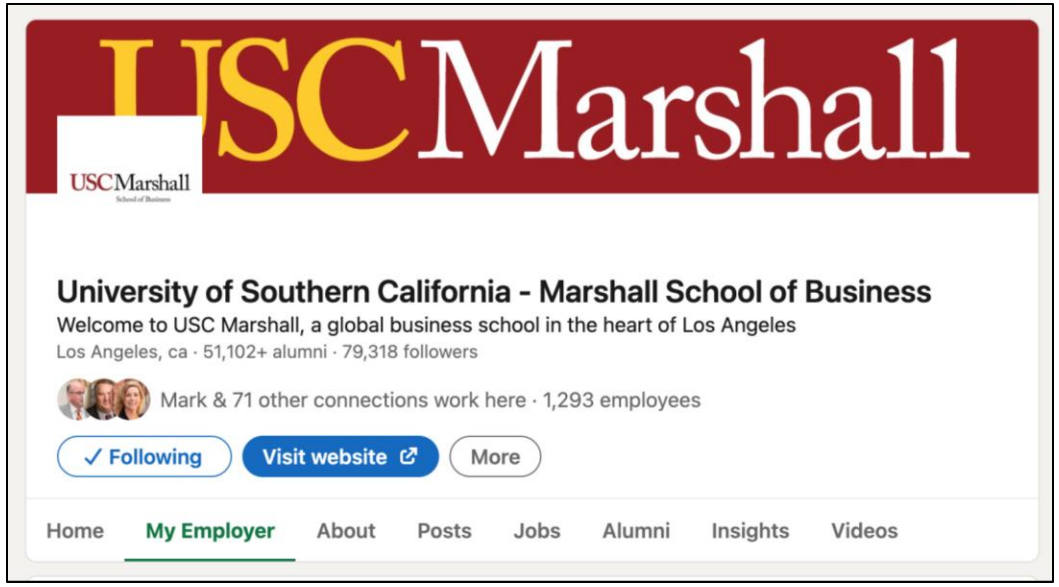
- For practice and to prepare for alumni chats
- Build a “knowledge foundation”
- Review Clubs’ suggested timeline

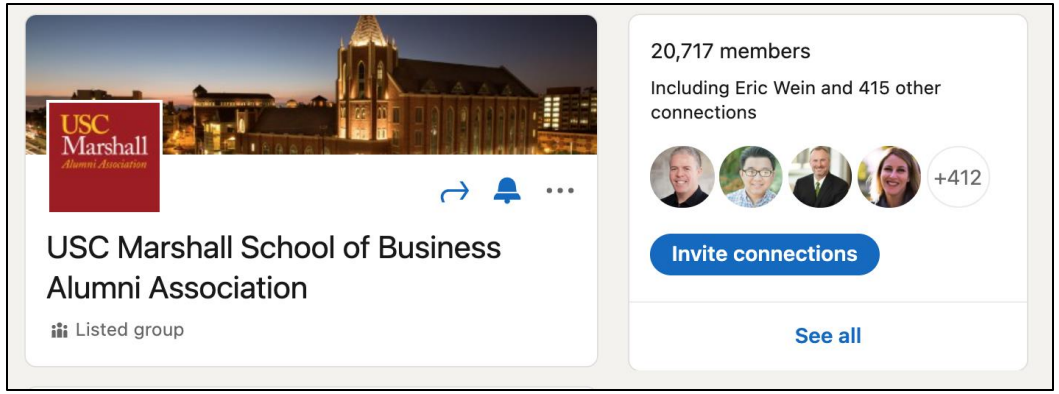
First Name	Company	Job Title	City	FT/Intern	Program
John Peter	Abernathy MacGregor Group	Vice President	Los Angeles	FT	FTMBA
Marina	Accenture	Operations Consultant	San Francisco	FT	FTMBA
Hung	Accenture	Associate Manager	San Francisco	FT	MBA.PM
Sam	Accenture	Associate Manager	San Francisco	FT	MBA.PM
Marissa	Adobe	Digital Strategy Associate	San Francisco	FT	FTMBA
Thuy (Amber)	Adobe	Data Product Manager	San Jose	FT	FTMBA
Rubab	Adobe	Senior Financial Analyst	San Jose	FT	MBA.PM
Nora	Adobe	Senior Financial Analyst	San Jose	FT	MBA.PM
Fangwei (Ferra)	Alvarez & Marsal	Associate	Los Angeles	FT	FTMBA
Christopher	Amazon	Finance Leadership Development Program Associate	Seattle	FT	FTMBA
Elad	Amazon	Senior Financial Analyst (FLDP Program)	Seattle	FT	FTMBA

Student Outcomes Spreadsheet
12Twenty Library > Networking Folder

- Schedule ***many*** chats with second-year students
- Talk to students from several industries and functions
- Build a relationship/trust, then ask for a contact referral

Expand Your Trojan Network





"Though I am very happy to connect, I really hope students ***add a personal note*** *when sending the requests, instead of the default LinkedIn messages. I got to know more about the importance of a note as I became an alum."*

– Marshall MBA Alumna, Class of 2021

⚠️ *Watch The LinkedIn Guys videos!*

Prepare for the Conversation

- ***Research***: LinkedIn, company website, industry news, press releases
- ***Practice your intro***: Why are you here? What connects you both?
- ***3 to 5 questions:*** their job, experience, team, projects, skills, challenges, firm culture, etc.
- ***Know your "ask":*** info, advice, insight, *not* a job or referral
- ***Be authentic!***
- ***Mind the time!***

12Twenty Library Resources

- *Networking and Informational Interview – Questions to Ask*
  - Starting point to create your own networking questions
- *Email Subject Lines that Get Networking Results*
  - Grab attention and get responses

Gratitude goes a long way

- Thank-you email
- Calendar
  - Pick a date to reach out again
  - Set a reminder to appear on that date
  - Choose a reason to reach out again
- Act on advice or information
  - Read the article or book
  - Go to the event
  - Update your resume
  - Reach out if you were referred to another person
- Follow through when the reminder pops up!

Maintain the connection

Do you need a response, or do you just want to refresh their mind to remember you?

- ***Got some advice or suggestions?*** Do it and report back! (no response needed)
- ***Share an article, a connection, a personal update.*** Mutually beneficial relationship (no response needed)
- ***Ask for another chat:*** (response required)
  - Need additional advice or insight
  - Request a new connection or introduction
  - Follow up on promises made

Networking is successful when . . .

QUESTIONS